



AI REVENUE GENERATION

Time has started serving ads to AI bots

By [Sara Guaglione](#) • July 30, 2026 •



Ivy Liu

Management Institute are among the first buyers.

Strange as that sounds, it's also logical. To understand why, it's important to go back to the start.

Last month, Time began converting all its webpages from HTML into markdown versions — stripped-down, text-only copies of each page that drop the design and images, making them easier for AI systems and agents to read. The easier that access, went the publisher's thinking, the better its chances of showing up in generative search queries.

Well, to a point. The jury is still out on how much of a bulwark markdown pages can be against the threat of falling search traffic. Putting ads in those pages is Time's way of squeezing some revenue out of its growing bot traffic while it waits to find out. To do that, the publisher is working with AI-powered ad tech platform Mobian to convert its pages into markdown and generate the agent ads. The ads themselves are formatted as FAQs with a brand's information and messaging, and labeled as sponsored content.

Time and Mobian claim this is the first time a publisher has served ads specifically targeting AI bots. More are already being lined up. Mark Howard, Time's chief operating officer, told Digiday Time's sales team is pitching agent ads to brands that have already converted their corporate websites into markdown files, as those brands are the ones already thinking about how to reach AI bots. The agent ads would be another way to reach LLMs, he said. Mobian's data shows about 15% of brands are powering their own markdown pages, according to Jonah Goodhart, co-founder and CEO of Mobian. As more brands bet on a two-track internet, that figure will likely rise.

"Maybe it's more important to influence the agent than even the human, because with a human you influence one person. When you influence ChatGPT, you're influencing potentially all of ChatGPT. If ChatGPT changes what it says about [a brand], it's massive and it's more than any one campaign could ever do," Goodhart said. "The big idea here is LLMs and AI want trusted

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Put another way, the ads give brands like Ally and the non-profit professional organization Project Management Institute another lever to pull on how they show up in generative search. LLMs can pick up a brand's information from the ad and index it, which can then shape AI-generated responses, which in turn, can influence humans using those AI answer engines.

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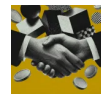
It's why the agent ads are viewed internally as part of Time's wider push to sell a GEO product to brands, built on what it's learned about where AI search engines pull information and when Time shows up in those summaries. How successful those efforts turn out to be will depend partly on how well the ads can monetize the surge of bot traffic Time has seen.

Howard declined to share the numbers behind that surge, but cited TollBit data showing the publisher sees more AI crawler requests for its content than the majority of the nearly 7,000 publisher sites in TollBit's network. Time sees an especially large spike in bot traffic when it launches a Time100 franchise list, such

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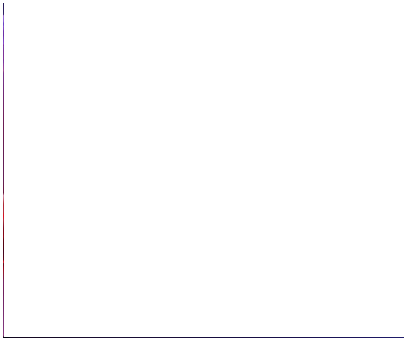
Howard said, mirroring Cloudflare data that shows more than half of all web traffic is now bot traffic.

“This is a growing traffic source, and therefore a growing source of inventory that we believe has huge value if we can continue to develop this product the way we have to get to this point to be able to have an offering to these brands,” he continued.

If it doesn’t get there it won’t be for lack of a simple process. Mobian can generate an AI brand ad in an FAQ format based on a brand brief. That agent ad is converted into a PDF for humans to review, then shared and approved by the client — not unlike the process for a standard branded content ad, Howard said. Mobian then puts those same FAQ questions to AI search engines to measure how the ad performs, tracking visibility, favorability and accuracy scores over time. The agent ads can be targeted contextually, against Time’s list franchises or by date range, Howard said.

And they won’t be cheap. Time is charging a premium for these agent ads. The thinking is that marketers are paying for the chance to shape the information LLMs retrieve since AI bot impressions on authoritative content are scarce and valuable, Howard said, and that scarcity is what gives advertisers the opening to influence it. Time sells one agent ad per markdown and measures AI bot traffic to that page, though Howard declined to share the pricing details.

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“This is an obvious extension of list sponsorship or franchise sponsorship, because we do know that there is a spike of the agents coming,” Howard said. “That ability to contextually align

and promotions agent-ready

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accordingly, it's all coming together in a way that we think is going to become a really important component of what our offering to our brand partners is."

How important remains to be seen. It's not clear if LLMs treat ads differently from editorial content, or even penalize promotional material when deciding what information to retrieve given it hasn't really been done before. But there is a precedent for cracking down on where and how ads can appear: Google began enforcing stricter standards and spam policies for ads on publishers' sites in the 2010s.

It's a thought not lost on Rob Derow, managing director and partner at BCG X, Boston Consulting Group's tech build and design unit. He said the biggest risk with markdown ads is that lack of rules governing how LLMs treat them – and how that could change. If LLMs eventually view this as a form of cloaking (an SEO tactic where a website delivers different content to search engine crawlers than what is shown to human users), publishers could see those pages become less effective, or be penalized for putting sponsored content in the markdown files. However, Derow said this can be easily monitored using AI visibility tools.

With that in mind, Time's agent ads contain a "sponsored content" disclosure at the top naming the brand client, even though there's no policy yet requiring that label. Ads are already being served to AI bots when they retrieve information from publishers' webpages, Howard and Goodhart noted.

"We don't know yet because this is brand new, and we believe that we are paving the first path forward here," Howard said. "But we are taking learnings from how we approached this kind of advertising in the past and applying it here, and whether or not you are going to end up needing that or not, we don't know."



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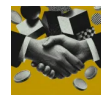
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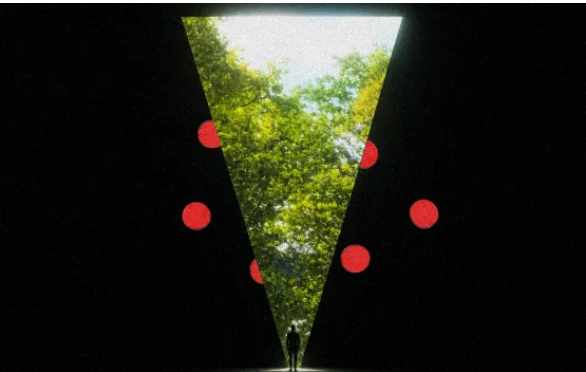


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